The Water Beneath Darsen

A dark fantasy story translated from A água sob Darsen

Codex, under the direction of Martin Melcop Neto

Martin Creative AI Lab · 2026

About this edition

This is a complete English translation of A água sob Darsen, the laboratory's standalone Portuguese P04 adaptation. Baldino, Aevren and Darsen come from the maintained seed. The incident, other characters and local rules were created for that adaptation. This book does not restore or replace an unavailable historical manuscript.

Portuguese text, English translation and editorial review by Codex under Martin Melcop Neto's portfolio direction. English reading edition 0.2.0 · 14 October 2026. No independent translator, reader or canon approval is claimed.

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1. The Caretaker’s Hand

The caretaker lost two fingers in the wheel, and I had to find them before I could clean the floor.

One was caught between the iron teeth. The other went down the drain. Aevren told me to leave that one until later. He was kneeling beside the bench, the caretaker’s arm across his lap; his skeletal hands held the dead wrist while the remaining thumb opened and closed.

“Raise the lamp, Baldino.”

A thread of tendon hung where the index finger had come away. Aevren pulled it with forceps. The thumb stopped.

“The splint won’t hold anymore,” I said.

“The splint holds. What’s left of the arm doesn’t.”

The body had been with us so long that I no longer remembered its face. We called what remained of a large man the caretaker: no legs below the knees, strapped to the bench beside the inlet wheel. Aevren touched his forearm, the hand closed on the lever, and I moved the bench into position. When Aevren took his fingers away, the arm dropped. Then we needed a wedge to hold the wheel still.

That night the water had turned the wheel a quarter turn on its own. I had my back to it, washing the inkwell. I heard the fingers snap, then the body strike the wall.

“It held yesterday,” I said.

Aevren lifted the wrist with the forceps.

“There was more of it yesterday.”

He did not ask why the wedge wasn’t in place. He had stopped asking a great many things after the first winter. I knew the passages, bought the lime, and could talk to the porters who refused to go down to a lich. In return, he let me use the kitchen and didn’t check every line I wrote.

I went for another strip of leather. Passing the wash valve, I laid my hand on the narrow pipe that disappeared into the wall. It was warm. Spring water entered the cistern from above, ran through the pipes beneath the tomb, and went on to Salt Street. That pipe was only supposed to carry the water we used to wash our tools. I had extended it to the back of Tila’s house.

My daughter worked through the night. By the time she came home, the public fountain was dry or crowded with people carrying buckets. She had asked me to bring her water twice a week. I had made a connection no one could see.

To buy the copper, I had taken money set aside for three replacements of ironwork. In the ledger, all three were finished. The caretaker’s hand could still close, and the wheel could still turn. I thought I had time.

In the book passage, Aevren had spread sheets beneath lead weights. Some bore drawings; others had holes where the drawings should have been. The previous week he had scraped a mistranslated word off a page and spent two days trying to work out whether the next sign meant pressure or position. The city’s water ran through works

older than Darsen. The dead man studying them did not remember how they had been made.

“The inlet’s stuck again,” I said, returning with the leather.

“Put in the big wedge.”

“It’ll split the rim.”

“If it splits, we’ll know where the weakness was.”

He said it without looking at me. I found a smaller wedge.

Before I could fit it, three knocks came from the service stairs. Then a fourth, from something heavier than a fist.

A grille hung in the corridor above the cistern. I usually lowered it at night. That day it was crooked, one side on the floor and the other hanging from its cable. At first I thought a sack of laundry had caught beneath the lower edge.

The sack was wearing boots.

Water dripped from the ceiling onto the soles. I crouched. The man’s neck was crushed against the step, and one hand, open between two bars, still seemed to be asking for room. I recognized the three white knots sewn into his coat cuff. Salt Street workers wore them so they could be recognized on inspections: it was hard to tell the saelir apart under the rain capes the guards gave them.

The man was not breathing. The lamp showed a dark pressure mark that would not go away when the grille was lifted.

“Baldino!” a woman called from the other side. “Stand back. We’re cutting the cable.”

I raised the lamp. I saw two spears and, behind them, Nera’s face. She kept the water records for the upper ward.

She looked at the body. Then she looked at me.

“How long have you been on shift?”

“Since sundown.”

“So he was here before you arrived?”

I opened my mouth. Aevren was calling from the cistern. The wheel struck the bench, each blow reaching the stairs with a short hammer sound.

“I didn’t come through this door,” I said.

It was true. It was not the answer she wanted.

2. The Inspection

Nera’s men raised the grille with two beams. The cable hadn’t snapped: its bracket had pulled out of the stone. I had signed off on replacing that bracket four months before.

They pulled the dead man out by his coat. A woman hurried down behind them and knelt on the step. She took off a glove, put her hand against his cheek, then straightened his collar to cover the place where the bar had marked him.

“Lesto,” she said.

She said his name only once.

I knew her. Sava fitted the pipes in Salt Street. She had repaired my old connection before I started diverting water. She got the hardest work because she could get her broad fingers into the wet joints; the same men who called her in for that complained about her hand when she asked them for a signature.

Lesto was her brother. I had never known him without his inspection coat.

Nera took a folded sheet from her pocket. The lower half was soaked.

“We sent an inspector at noon. He didn’t come back. The water stopped in the lower ward before the second bell. We came to check the inlet and shut the intake until we can make a safe passage.”

“You brought spears to check an intake?” Aevren asked.

He had appeared behind me. He carried the caretaker’s arm wrapped in a cloth, as though he hadn’t thought where he would put it. One guard stepped back. Nera did not.

“The last man who came is lying on the floor.”

“And the first thing you do is point iron at the person working the wheel.”

She lowered the spear beside her with her palm.

“Show me the cistern.”

Aevren did not move.

“I won’t close an inlet using a drawing that doesn’t match it.”

“Then show me the right drawing.”

He went back along the corridor. Nera took that as permission, and the group followed. Sava stayed beside her brother. As I passed, she caught my sleeve.

“Did you check this grille?”

I looked at the sheet in Nera’s hand.

“I did.”

Sava let go of my sleeve. She didn’t need another question; she was already following my gaze.

In the cistern, the water had risen above the morning mark. The black wheel on the far wall controlled the spring inlet. Near the stairs stood the smaller wheel, connected to the outlet for Salt Street. At the bottom of

the tank, beneath the murky water, the drain led to the river. Aevren had made me repeat it so often that I could have named those three routes in my sleep.

Nera read the marks on the wall.

“Where’s it losing water?”

“We don’t know yet,” I said.

She pointed to the copper pipe.

“Where does that go?”

“Washing.”

“After the washing.”

Aevren turned his head. For the first time that night, he seemed to be listening to me closely.

Nera didn’t wait for an answer. Sava was coming down with the other guard. Lesto had been left on the landing. Sava passed the pipe, struck it with a wrench, and saw water come out of a joint I hadn’t soldered properly.

“There’s enough pressure to feed a house,” she said. “The wash line goes down, Baldino. This one goes up.”

“It’s reused water.”

“Show me where it comes back.”

There was no return connection.

The black wheel turned again. The new leather stretched around the caretaker’s wrist, and the small wedge jumped into the water. Aevren stepped closer, touched the forearm strapped to the bench, and closed the dead hand on the lever. The handle stopped moving.

One guard began to pray. Sava opened her tool bag.

“That worn, he won’t hold it,” she told Aevren.

“I noticed.”

“Then move the bench. We’ll brace it from outside.”

He kept his fingers on the dead arm.

Sava went back to the smaller wheel and lowered her wrench through the inspection opening. She brought up a thick lump of sludge with fibers caught in it.

“The outlet screen’s blocked,” she said. “The water stays here while the street goes dry.”

Nera read the cleaning date in the ledger. It was that week’s. I had copied the previous week’s entry, which I had copied from the week before. The pipe to Tila still took water before the screen.

“If the hand drops, does more come in?”

“All the pressure the spring is sending,” I said.

“Close the street outlet. I’m not sending this into people’s houses.”

“It’ll rise here,” Sava said.

“I know. We have people at the fountain. First we isolate the dirty water, then we close the inlet.”

It was not an absurd order. The water had touched the caretaker’s remains, carried rust, and brought something dark from the lower passage. Nera sent one man to the outlet. She asked the other to fetch the beams they had used on the grille.

The first man began turning the smaller wheel.

“Not all the way,” Sava warned. “Leave a finger’s width until we have the brace.”

Nera signaled with her hand. The guard obeyed. The sound in the pipes grew sharper.

I looked for the big wedge. I found the labels for the ironwork I hadn’t bought. The big wedge no longer existed: I had sawn it up to prop the copper joint behind Tila’s house.

Four people were waiting for me to come back with something that could hold the wheel.

3. The Lower Gallery

I brought the beams. Sava wedged one between the rim and the wall, but the socket was so worn away that the end began to slip out before she finished tightening it.

“Who put filler in here?” she asked.

I had said the filler would keep the damp out. In fact, it hid the opening where the new ironwork should have been anchored.

“I did.”

Sava picked a piece out with her nail. It came away without effort.

Aevren looked at the wheel, then at the ledger hanging beside the stairs. I didn’t know whether he was counting the money or the days we had worked side by side.

“What else wasn’t replaced?” he asked.

“The grille.”

Sava stopped scraping.

“The grille’s bracket,” I added.

The guard at the far end of the beam let go of it and seized my coat. He didn’t hit me. Nera called him by name, Eno, and told him to take hold of the beam again.

“Later,” she told me. “If we get out, you’ll explain every signature.”

Something cracked inside the tank. The caretaker tipped forward, tearing the straps out of the bench. Aevren kept

his hand on the arm, but the elbow bent the wrong way. The hand closed without moving the lever.

The beam swung toward Eno. Sava pulled him aside by his belt. The iron struck the stair’s edge, broke off a chip, and lodged across it. The black wheel spun freely, one full turn.

Water poured from the inlet into the tank with a force that made us shout.

Nera tried to reach the lever. I caught her before she stepped into the rim’s path.

“You can’t stop it with your hand!”

“How do we get to the drain?”

It was the right question. I looked at Aevren.

The drain had a sluice gate beneath the cistern. Opening it to the river would lower the tank, but the mechanism was in the lower gallery, behind the book storeroom. We kept that passage shut. The gallery’s side wall was cracked; when the drain opened, some of the water came back through the crack.

I had marked that wall as repaired in the same month as the grille.

“This way,” I said.

Aevren went ahead. Water already covered the first stair. Nera sent Eno up to warn the men in the corridor: the street outlet had to be closed completely, and no one was to drink from the fountain. She followed us with the second beam.

Sava passed me in the book passage. Aevren tried to stop her.

“Don’t step on the sheets.”

She lifted her bag clear of the shelves.

“Then take the sheets off the floor.”

The lich moved toward a table. The water arrived first, slipping beneath the gallery door and lifting the bottom sheets. A lead weight slid. Aevren caught a corner of paper, but it tore off in his hand.

Beyond the door were a short staircase and a maintenance shaft. The beam that worked the drain lay across the shaft, supported by a hanging counterweight. Someone had to pull the beam into its socket and hold it there while another person released the brake. After that, the counterweight would lift the sluice gate.

The cracked side of the wall was the side with the chain.

“Don’t take another step there,” Sava said, looking at the floor.

I stood still. The stone beneath my foot had moved.

Nera braced the spare beam between two walls. Sava looped a rope around it and another around the official’s waist. Nera climbed down to the mechanism. From the doorway I could see her head, her outstretched hand, and the water rising over the tiles.

She reached the brake. The chain went taut. The sluice gate didn’t move.

“The beam!” she shouted.

Sava and I pulled. We stopped a handspan short of the socket. We pulled again. I felt something give beneath the floor each time we strained.

Nera tried to hold the brake open with her shoulder. Water filled the place where she had planted her foot, and the chain ran across her hand. When Sava hauled her up by the rope, two fingers were bent inside her glove.

Nera climbed out without letting go of the chain with her other hand. Sava made her release it. The chain ran, the brake closed, and the counterweight struck its support.

“I need someone down there while you fit the beam,” Nera said.

“The floor’s going to go,” Sava said.

“Then someone who doesn’t have to climb out afterward.”

She looked at Aevren. He took the cloth off the caretaker’s arm.

For a moment we stared at the broken thing.

“Not enough of the joint is left,” he said.

“What about your own hand?” Nera asked.

Aevren tried to pull the brake with his fingers. The handle turned. He drew his hand back, leaving a small white chip on the iron. He looked at the chip before wrapping the caretaker’s arm again.

I thought of Lesto. I tried not to look at Sava, which was a very poor way of hiding the thought.

She held the clasp of her bag.

“No.”

Nera opened her mouth.

“If the brake closes again,” Aevren cut in, “I take my hand away, and the body stops. I can’t tell it to keep going from up here.”

He held the caretaker’s arm by the shoulder to show us. The dead hand hung loose. The exposed tendon no longer connected the wrist to the elbow.

I had watched it every day. Even so, for a moment I had hoped he could make the dead man go down into the shaft alone, work the brake, and come back.

“Can you keep your hand on the body while we pull?” Sava asked.

Aevren looked at the narrow ledge beside the chain.

“I can try.”

“And if he breaks like that one?”

“He breaks.”

The water reached the feet of the book table. Aevren turned his head. Then he looked back at Sava.

She closed her bag, leaving out the rope and the largest wrench.

“I’m going to get my brother. You don’t touch him until I come back.”

She passed me in the doorway. I wanted to follow.

“You stay at the beam, Baldino.”

She did not raise her voice. I stayed.

4. The Counterweight

Eno and the man guarding the stairs brought Lesto on a door they had pulled from the corridor. Sava walked beside his head. When they reached the storeroom, she told them to stop.

She unfastened her brother’s coat. She found a service key in the inner pocket and put it in her own bag. She did not touch the other pockets. She folded the coat, set it on a dry box, and went back to the door.

“Only his arm,” she told Aevren. “Don’t lift his head.”

The lich knelt. He touched Lesto’s forearm with two fingers. The dead man’s hand slowly closed.

Sava caught the wrist before it closed all the way.

“Wait.”

Aevren took his fingers away. The hand hung loose again.

She ran her thumb over her brother’s palm. There was a burn near the base of the fingers, old enough to have healed smooth. Sava covered it with the leather strip she used to protect her hands at work. Only then did she let Aevren repeat the movement.

The leather creaked. The hand gripped.

Nera had taken off her glove. Eno bound her broken fingers, leaving her good hand free. She checked the rope tied around Aevren’s waist and the knot that would hold Lesto. The lich had to push his sleeve up so the rope

wouldn’t slip over the cloth. I could have closed my hand around his whole forearm.

“If I fall, pull here,” he said, pointing to the bend of his elbow.

Eno nodded, looking at Sava.

They lowered Lesto through the opening. The water turned his body sideways. Sava let out more rope until his arm reached the brake. Aevren climbed down after him, bracing his feet against the stone ledge.

From above, I could see Lesto’s sleeve, the skeletal hand beneath it, and part of his wet hair. Aevren tried to close the fingers on the iron. The hand slipped.

“A little to the left,” Sava said.

The body swung. The hand closed again and caught the brake this time.

Nera took one end of the beam. I stood at the other. The water reached our ankles and hid the floor from sight. Sava put a pale strip of cloth beside the socket so we would know how far to pull.

We pulled. The beam moved the width of a palm.

Aevren raised the dead arm. The chain came free of the brake with a sound that made Eno step back.

“More,” Sava told me.

I pulled again. The counterweight sank a little, and the end of the beam passed over the socket without dropping in. Nera tried to push it sideways. Her injured hand struck the wall, and she cried out.

Sava couldn’t let go of the rope. If the body turned, Aevren would lose contact.

“Underneath, Baldino. There’s a loop.”

I knew the loop. I had cleaned that part many times without looking inside it. I bent down, put my arm through, and found the iron under the water. I pushed upward with my shoulder.

The beam settled into its socket. For an instant I felt I was holding it.

Then the weight came. Something shifted inside my shoulder, and my arm stuck in a position where I could neither use it nor pull it out. The floor gave way beneath my knee. I tried to call Nera, but the air went out before her name.

She caught my collar with her good hand. I was sliding, and the loop was taking my arm with it. Sava passed a turn of the body’s rope to Eno, set her foot against the wall, and held the beam above me.

“Let go of the loop!”

I couldn’t open my fingers anymore. She struck my wrist with the butt of the wrench. My hand let go. Nera dragged me back, and my arm came with me, though I could no longer feel where it ended.

The beam was in place, but the chain was still caught. Lesto had doubled over in the water. His hand still closed; it was the body turning that pulled the brake the wrong way.

Sava tightened the rope. Eno tried to do the same.

From the shaft, Aevren called my name.

A crack opened beneath the lowest shelf. Water swept through the storeroom and carried the first box of sheets toward the stairs. Aevren looked at it. I was lying beside the door; I saw the neck of bone turn and the arm start to pull away from Lesto’s.

“Hold!” Sava shouted.

The dead hand opened. The brake dropped halfway, catching the chain again. Aevren put his fingers back on the arm, but Lesto was no longer in the right position.

Eno pulled the rope so hard that a loop cut his palm. The body rose. Aevren had to stretch his arm as far as it would go to keep contact.

The box struck the wall and broke open. The sheets came out into the water, one after another. One bore the drawing of the drain. I recognized the double line Aevren had managed to reconstruct the previous afternoon.

“Move the body to the right,” he told Sava.

She shifted her grip on the rope.

“Like this?”

“Hold him.”

Aevren reached his own hand down to Lesto’s and closed both around the brake. Sava kept her brother tilted. Nera pushed the beam with the toe of her boot.

The counterweight fell.

The first surge from the drain threw water in our faces. The second tore a stone out of the crack. Aevren vanished

into the water up to his chest, still touching Lesto’s arm. The shaft began to empty, but the book passage took all the water coming through the broken wall.

I crawled to the lich’s rope. I couldn’t pull him up with my good arm. Nera took the same rope and called Eno. Together they hauled him to the edge.

When Aevren took his hand away, Lesto’s arm released the brake. This time the chain had already run to the end. The counterweight held the sluice gate open.

Sava pulled her brother up. His body scraped the wall, and she shouted at Eno not to let his head strike it. He let go of Aevren’s rope and moved to hers. Nera held the lich while the other body came up.

Lesto lay on the door between us. The hand that had worked the brake was open. Sava took off the leather strip, straightened the fingers one by one, and bent down to rest her forehead against his. She did not say his name again.

We waited for the noise to lessen.

In front of us, the water in the cistern was falling. Behind us, the water carried off whatever it found in the storeroom. Aevren stood with Nera’s help and walked to the shelves. He tried to lift a box. Its lid fell apart before it cleared the water.

He put the box back. He did not look at me.

5. Morning Water

We came out by the service stairs, carrying Lesto. The grille stood against the wall. I passed the loose bracket and saw the remains of the filler I had used to make it look new.

In the street, Nera ordered a cart for the dead man and another for me. I tried to say I could walk. When they helped me stand, I vomited on the step.

Sava would not let me ride on her brother’s cart.

The sun had not risen when we reached Salt Street. A few people stood beside the fountain with empty buckets. Nera spoke to the workmen, explained that the water would stay shut off, and sent Eno for carts from the upper ward. The first supply would come from there, until the cistern and outlet were clean. Two women began to protest. She stayed and listened while her fingers were splinted.

Tila came for my key. Someone had told her I was on the cart. She had left work without changing her apron.

“They said you fell.”

“I did.”

She saw Sava beside the other cart.

“Who is that?”

I told her Lesto’s name. She didn’t know him.

“The grille I should have repaired,” I began.

Tila sat on the edge of the cart. She waited for me to finish.

I told her about the bracket, the wheel, and the money. When I mentioned the pipe behind her house, she raised her head.

“Is that why the water came back?”

I nodded.

“I thought they’d repaired the street.”

She wrapped the key in her apron. Then she went to open the house for the man who would treat my shoulder. She did not tell me I had done it all for her, and I didn’t have the courage to try saying so.

Nera took the ledger before noon. I asked her to leave the last week’s sheet, but she took them all. Aevren acknowledged the marks he had used to approve the repairs. According to Eno, he took longer to hand over the damaged sheets from the gallery: they showed where the drain ran, and he didn’t want just anyone going in there again.

Nera gave him the names of the workers who would return. Sava was among them.

Three days later they removed the pipe from Tila’s house. Only then did I receive the first summons. No one had yet decided what I would pay, or where the money would come from. My work in the tomb was over. Tila put the kitchen tools in a box so I wouldn’t try to go back to work before I could move my arm.

When the water returned to Salt Street, instructions came with it: boil what you meant to drink. The cistern had been cleaned, but the neighborhood’s pipes still brought up sludge. From the window I saw a woman covering the buckets she carried. She was furious with someone; I couldn’t hear who.

Sava came that first afternoon, while the man tending my shoulder was still preparing the bandage.

She knocked before she came in. Tila was in the kitchen and offered her boiled water. Sava drank standing up, in two swallows. She gave the glass back and stayed by the table.

“They’ll shroud Lesto tomorrow. They want me to sign that the mark on his hand came from the shaft.”

I looked at her hand. The strain of the rope had left a purple line beneath her fingers.

“It did,” I said.

“I know where it came from. You were there.”

That was what she wanted from me: to show up and say what I had seen, without making the night into a fall on the stairs.

The next day Tila came with me to the place where Sava’s family was waiting. The water they would use to wash Lesto had come on one of the upper ward’s carts. His coat lay folded on a chair, with a service key on top.

Tila stayed near the door. I approached the body. The grille’s pressure mark was still on his neck. The hand we had used was clean, lying beside the other.

I told them where the mark had been made. A man from the family asked me to show him how the brake moved. I used my good hand. He looked at Lesto’s wrist and called a woman I didn’t know. They began to make a splint to protect it when they shrouded him.

I was about to step back, but Sava made room beside the body.

“Here. I haven’t finished telling them.”

I sat where she pointed.

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